

## Field Assignment: Beat Q&A – Due Feb. 13

Cayce Reese | Business | Budget | Oconee State Bank | Storytelling

### Q&A: Cayce Reese on Intersection of Community Banking, Storytelling

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#### Cayce Reese Video Interview

Cayce Reese, marketing and business development coordinator for Oconee State Bank, speaks at the Reporting I Beat Meet & Greet at the Studio 100 Journalism Building, Athens, Georgia, on Thursday, Feb. 12, 2026. Reese transitioned from an executive assistant role to help lead the bank's community storytelling and branding. [Photo/David McFarland]

Cayce Reese serves as the marketing and business development coordinator for Oconee State Bank. Sitting at the intersection of local finance and community storytelling, Reese offered a unique perspective on how community banks stay competitive in a digital age. She discussed the balance between profit and customer

service, the importance of financial honesty for young professionals and the critical role integrity plays in the future of business.

Q: What did you learn about the bank's mission while working at the executive level? You transitioned from an executive assistant to business development. And how does that make you a better storyteller?

A: It honestly transforms the way that you see things when you are able to sit in those strategic meetings. You hear the executives explain what the vision is and not just the fun story elements. You know what is driving the engine. So, every time on board we would discuss when they hoped to see our shareholders would be stewarded, that started to bank into my mind. As a storyteller, I do not just focus on the feelings. It has to drive results. And how do you drive results without knowing the results? You cannot. So I think it is a beautiful combination to have the organizational skills and to have the strategic understanding. I know when someone says ROI and is talking about our deposits needing to grow. It is not this abstract thing for me.

Q: What is the biggest challenge facing businesses in your industry right now?

A: Banking is kind of an oddity because it is essential and it is everywhere. But we are dealing with a lot of the ebbs and flows of the economy. When you are a banker, you are trying to make sure your expenses are low. You are trying to make sure your efficiency is there because you have to profit. You have to be able to turn over what is being invested into your hands. I think making those critical decisions that cater to the customers really well is vital. You cannot neglect the customers. You have to serve them well, but you also have to be kind of frugal. Finding that sweet spot is a challenge.

Q: When you meet small business owners in Athens or, even, UGA students what would your advice be when managing money?

A: There is a really good book called, "Unreasonable Hospitality". There is a section in the book where it talks about how you have to prioritize what matters. Manage your operational costs well, but then find that five to 10 percent where you can just have a little bit of pizzazz. Find ways to manage what's essential efficiently but then have fun. This was something, personally, I had to figure out. My parents told me over again, "Casey, where's the fun?" Make sure there is room for that, so that when you do get that urge, it's not breaking the bank because you already thought about it. It is preplanned spontaneity that allows for the wow moments that happen.

Q: Based on that, what would your advice be for people living paycheck to paycheck, including myself?

A: I have been there. There are still moments where I am there. If there are opportunities for you to assess what is essential, you must ask how we do that well. Be honest about those things. That gets in the way a lot of times because we are not honest with ourselves and we are not honest with our community. When you shackle yourself, you are not moving.

Q: What skills matter most to you looking into the future of business?

A: Integrity. I think that when you sit in spaces where there is a high level of trust people are trusting you with major decisions that impact every single day of their lives. It is not a small thing. Also, developing our desire to learn is important. Just staying around people who have more insight than us is key because everything is evolving. The future is always going to be moving and bringing something new up. Even with AI, if you cannot navigate AI with integrity then we are in trouble.

Q: What is a major project or milestone you are looking forward to in 2026?

A: One of the bigger projects is getting our team educated on Canva Enterprise. We are setting up the structure and making sure our brand kits are in there properly. But really, it is about how we create strong cohesion so that in every area we show up there is consistency. It is good work and necessary work.

**Comments trimmed for length and clarity.**

**Reflection:** This beat interview taught me a lot of things. It has taught me that a successful interview is less about asking perfect questions but more about having genuine engagement with the source. While business reporting can be intimidating, I realised that managing natural conversation and active listening is what really matters. I believe that instead of being perfect, being able to have a genuine conversation helps yield detailed answers.